

LANGUE VIVANTE 1 — ANGLAIS

Épreuve écrite

Durée de l'épreuve : **3 heures** — Coefficient : **4**
Compréhension de l'écrit : 10 points — Expression écrite : 10 points

L'usage du dictionnaire et de tout appareil électronique est interdit. Le sujet comporte trois documents, A, B et C. Les réponses à la partie « compréhension » doivent être rédigées en anglais.

Dossier — Elsewhere in Time

Trois œuvres qui parlent de leur présent en se déplaçant dans le temps : l'une part vers l'an 802 701, l'autre redoute le siècle qui vient, la troisième emprunte à un passé qui n'est pas le sien.

DOCUMENT A

In the summer of 1996, a British band called Jamiroquai released a song that almost nobody expected to become a hit. *Virtual Insanity* is not an easy piece of pop music. Its chords belong to jazz, its bass line belongs to the 1970s, and its lyrics belong to nobody's idea of a dancefloor. The singer, Jay Kay, worries about overpopulation, about scientists rewriting the human genome, about a planet quietly running out of room. The chorus repeats that we all live underground.

The image was not invented. Jay Kay had recently walked through an underground shopping city in Sendai, in northern Japan, with one of the band's musicians. Thousands of people were going about their day beneath the street: shops, cafés, corridors, artificial light. Nobody seemed troubled by it. What struck him was not the technology itself but how ordinary it had become, and how easily a species could stop noticing that it had moved indoors for good.

The video did the rest. Directed by Jonathan Glazer, it shows the singer in a bare white room where the floor appears to slide away beneath his feet while he keeps dancing. There is no computer trickery in it. The walls were mounted on wheels and pushed around a camera fixed to one of them; the floor never moved at all. Glazer later described the effect as a magician's trick. Audiences found it unsettling long before they could explain why, which is perhaps the most accurate description of the song itself.

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Texte rédigé pour les besoins de l'épreuve.

DOCUMENT B

A hundred and one years before that song, in 1895, a young English writer named H. G. Wells published a short novel about a man who builds a machine and rides it into the future. He does not travel a few centuries. He travels eight hundred thousand years, and what he finds there is not a paradise of flying cars but a quiet, warm, sunlit world in which humanity has split into two.

Above ground live the Eloi: small, gentle, beautiful, incurious. They eat fruit, they play, they cannot read, and they are frightened of the dark. Below ground live the Morlocks: pale, silent creatures who never come up in daylight, who tend the machines, and who — the traveller slowly understands — feed on the people upstairs.

What makes the book uncomfortable is the explanation the traveller offers. This did not happen by accident, he argues, and it did not happen quickly. It began in his own century, with factories placed underground, with railways buried beneath cities, with one class of people spending its working life below the surface while another lived in the light. Comfort above, labour below. Give that arrangement enough time, he suggests, and it will not stay a social difference. It will become a biological one.

Wells was thirty when he wrote it. He was not predicting the year 802 701. He was describing London in 1895 and asking his readers to imagine what it would look like if nothing changed.

Texte rédigé pour les besoins de l'épreuve, d'après H. G. Wells, The Time Machine (1895).

DOCUMENT C

In Paris, in the mid-1990s, a group of five young men who called themselves Alliance Ethnik were doing something rather different with time. They were not looking forward at all. They were looking back — and sideways, across the Atlantic, at a decade they had been too young to live through.

Their music was built out of American soul and funk from the 1970s: round bass lines, dry drums, warm electric keyboards, the sound of records made before any of them were born. To get it right they brought in Bob Power, an American producer who had worked in New York with A Tribe Called Quest and De La Soul. On *Honesty et Jalousie*, released in 1995, the verses are rapped in French, the chorus is sung in English by an American singer, and the DJ scratches a short fragment lifted from an American record of 1990. Even the title cannot decide which language it belongs to.

It would be easy to call this imitation. It is not, or not only. Borrowing an American past gave these young Frenchmen something they could not find in the French present: a way of sounding warm, confident and modern at the same time, and a family to belong to. The past they were quoting was not theirs. That, arguably, was the point.

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Texte rédigé pour les besoins de l'épreuve.

I. Compréhension de l'écrit

10 points

Answer all the questions in English. Quote from the texts when you can, and give the letter of the document you are using.

Document A

1. Say in your own words what the singer is afraid of. Give **three** different fears mentioned in the text. **1,5 pt**
2. Where did the idea of living underground come from, and why did that place make such an impression on him? **1,5 pt**
3. Explain how the video was made. Why does the director compare it to a magician's trick? **1 pt**

Document B

4. Describe the two peoples the traveller meets. Give two characteristics of each. **1,5 pt**
5. According to the traveller, how did this division come about? Explain his reasoning in two or three sentences. **1,5 pt**

Document C

6. What exactly did the French group borrow, and from where? Give **three** precise elements taken from the text. **1,5 pt**

Documents A, B and C

7. « All three works use another time — the future or the past — in order to talk about their own present. » Discuss this statement in about eight lines, using **one precise element from each document**. **1,5 pt**

II. Expression écrite

10 points

Choose **one** of the two subjects below and write about **300 words**. Indicate clearly which subject you have chosen, and give the number of words at the end of your text.

Subject 1. Wells imagined a future in which humanity had split in two; Jay Kay feared a future in which technology would leave us no room to breathe. Which of these two warnings speaks more directly to your own generation, and why? Support your answer with precise examples.

Subject 2. Two hundred years from now, a historian finds a recording of a song made in 1996 and tries to explain to her students what the people who made it were afraid of, and whether they were right. Write her account.

Fin du sujet.